Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Lilace Mellin Guignard's "Lullaby in Fracktown"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the effect of repetition on the tone of Guignard's "Lullaby in Fracktown" include

alliteration,
ambiguity,
aphorism,
apostrophe,
assonance,
auditory imagery,
consonance,
diction,
enjambment,
fatalism,
heteromerous (mosaic) rhyme,
irony,
lullaby,
metonymy,
onomatopoeia,
ploce,
rhyme,
rhythm,
setting,
sigmatism,
stoicism,
tone,
villanelle (extended), and
visual imagery.

The student's analysis should include a recognition that while a lullaby is meant to ease a child to sleep, the speaker's easing repeats the foundationally paradoxical "Daddy still has a job to lose," and her attempt to ease the child to sleep is further troubled by line 15's problematic "someday too you'll have a job to lose."

The poem's repetition takes many forms, the most obvious being the sequencing of lines that constitutes the villanelle. Perhaps the villanelle's rhyming dynamic suggests the uncertainty associated with the father's job and the son's future and, by extension, the environment's future. The poem's shaken, as it were, *aba* order of end rhyme is not characteristic of a traditional lullaby, which usually features, for a child, a more predictable (e.g., *abab*; *abcb*; *aa bb*) rhyme sequence.

The alliteration and assonance, as schemes of repetition, carry both the love (line 2) and the warning (lines 13-15) that frame the contrasts informing the speaker's tone. The contestant might remark on the ambiguity of "blue"—all that is inherent in blue as the color associated with what is bright and promising and what is *boy*, and (in contrast) all that is suggested both by a concerned mother's being blue and with the extraction industries' workers' blues.

What the contestant makes of the speaker's tone itself is secondary to how the contestant points to the repetition of words, imagery, and phrasing, all of which are constituent of the villanelle's form.